

Exhibit 17

Wired UK - Highlights from Founders of the Future Forum

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Founders of the Future

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Highlights from Founders of the Future Forum

The 2018 Founders Forum focussed on tackling diversity, fostering well-being and sharing strategies for the future of our cities

 **SAVE**



FOUNDERS OF THE FUTURE

THE THIRD ANNUAL Founders of the Future Forum was held on June 12 in central London, bringing together founders present and founders of the future to share strategies for building tomorrow's companies. Discussions and talks touched on the importance of tackling the lack of diversity in tech, how we can better preserve the wellbeing of founders who often face burnout, and why – from those who've been there – starting a startup isn't always the way.

This year's event considered the question: What type of founder are you? – a theme introduced by hosts Pierre-Simon Ntiruhungwa and Liam Tootill. This provocation shaped the agenda and challenged attendees to think about the obstacles involved in setting up a company, what kind of place they would hope to occupy as founder, their own long-term wellbeing, and the mindset needed for such an undertaking.

Several curated panels addressed questions of health and wellbeing in the context of demanding human endeavours: Christine Ohuruogu MBE, a British track and field athlete who specialises in the 400 metres (the event for which she is a former Olympic, World and Commonwealth champion) shared how dedicated training and daily routine helped her to succeed.

“As athletes our routine is what sets us up... when you're on the starting blocks how do you handle the pressure in that moment?” Ohuruogu asked. “The real beauty of our sport is we start preparation months and months and months before, and that's the bit that people don't actually see. And when you're preparing for an Olympic final or a World Champs final, everything that you do is woven into your day to day to prepare for that.”

Hoping to encourage prospective founders while adding a dose of harsh reality, a panel called “Words from founders: why you shouldn’t start a startup” brought together a number of entrepreneurs who did, eventually, get there, to share battle tales about what it took out of them.

From shareholder disagreements, to mismanaging finances, from board pressures, to overcoming anxiety and bouts of self-doubt, founders Sarah McVittie (Dressipi), Frank Meehan (SmartUp), Damian Kimmelman (DueDil), Tugce Bulut (Streetbees), Michael Acton Smith (Calm.com) and Brent Hoberman CBE (lastminute.com, Founders Forum) cautioned eager business minds about the difficulties involved.

Guests heard from presumptive Lord Mayor, Peter Estlin, whose theme for his year in office, beginning November 2018, is *Shaping Tomorrow’s City Today*. This forward-facing theme brought together elements of the City of London’s corporation strategy so as to resonate with businesses and the people living and working in the city. Estlin focussed on what it means to prepare for the city we will live in 25 years from now, as industries become ever-more digitised. It touched on:

- **Digital innovation:** growth across fintech, medtech and greater integration of technology into a huge range of sectors is huge economic potential.
- **Smart cities:** as our cities become bigger, more technological and more urbanised, how do we keep them both sustainable and liveable?
- **Digital skills:** making sure the right training is in place for technologists-in-the-making.

Following the address, participants were asked to come together in groups and invent their own solutions for problems with pollution, overcrowding, travel and energy.

One of the event’s standout themes addressed the lack of diversity in tech. June Sarpong MBE (Diversify), Trina van Pelt (Intel Capital) and Mark Martin (Urban Teacher, UKBlackTech) drew on their personal experiences – setting up companies to tackle the gender gap in tech, writing books tackling the broad problems of diversity, and fighting to overcome ‘invisible’ barriers just to have their voices heard – to tell of the importance of centring women, ethnic minorities and disadvantaged people. Diversity is important in itself, and an

important spur to innovation in any business. People from different walks of life bring different ideas to the table, attendees heard.

June Sarpong told of how Danielle Harmer, Chief People Officer at Metro Bank, built an entirely new process for hiring talent: “she scrapped the criteria for who was employed within the company and they set-up their own training programme, so they were not hiring from Russell Group universities.” Setting up links with local further education colleges, Metro Bank used their own metric to assess who would be a right fit for the company. “They made sure that their team during the interview process consisted of four people from diverse backgrounds,” to keep unconscious bias to a minimum, Sarpong said.

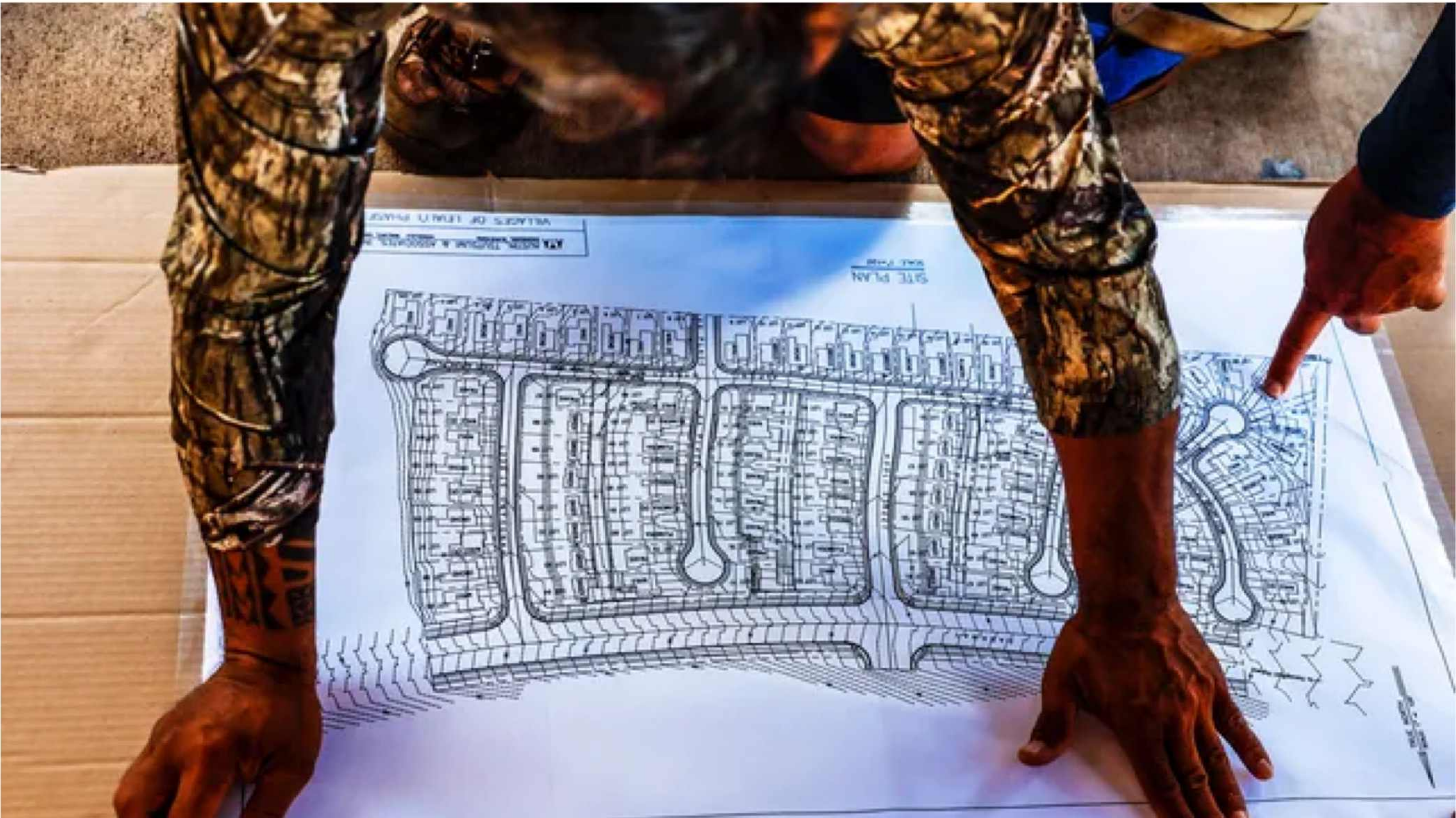
This article was originally published by WIRED UK

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